Jahnava Devi

Джахнава-деви · @jahnava

The Shakti of Nityananda

Jahnava Devi is the eternal energy, the shakti, of Nityananda Prabhu, and His consort in Gaura-lila. She is called Jahnava Thakurani, Jahnava Mata — “Mother Jahnava,” Jahnava Ishvari, that is, the Queen, and Nityanandeshvari; in the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” her name is Jahnavi. Together with her elder sister Vasudha she is a transcendental (aprakrita) shakti of Nityananda; one of the biographies calls her “Nityananda-svarupini,” His second self, and another says still more boldly: Jahnava Devi is Nityananda Prabhu Himself.[1]

She is also called “Bhakta-svarupini” — devotion personified, a treasury of prema-bhakti; in her divine majesty (aishvarya) and divine sweetness (madhurya) are equally wonderful. Like Nityananda, she is a jagad-guru, a teacher of love for Krishna to the whole world. When Gaurasundara and Nityananda withdrew Their pastimes, it was she who was honoured as guru in all three holy lands — in Gauda-mandala, in Kshetra-mandala, that is, in Puri, and in Vraja-mandala. By her mercy she delivered many sinners and godless people.

Daughter of Surya Dasa

Jahnava's father was Surya Dasa Sarakhela, also known as Suryadasa Pandita and Surya Pandita. He was dear to Sri Chaitanya, and Nityananda and Gauranga too regarded him as Their intimate devotee. Her mother's name was Bhadravati; one of the biographies calls her most fortunate — it fell to her to become the mother of two shaktis of Nityananda. The elder daughter was Vasudha, the younger Jahnava.

Jahnava's grandfather was Kamsari Mishra, a brahmana of the Vatsa gotra from the Ghoshal family. He and his wife Kamala Devi had six sons, and Surya Dasa was the third. His elder brothers were Damodara and Jagannatha, his younger ones Gauridasa Pandita, Krishnadasa Sarakhela and Nrisimha Chaitanya. Gauridasa, Surya Dasa's younger brother, moved with his permission from Shaligrama to Ambika on the Ganges (“Bhakti-ratnakara” 7.330–331); his niece would one day weep at his samadhi in Vrindavana. Another uncle, Krishnadasa Sarakhela, was later with her at the festival in Kheturi.[2]

Surya Dasa lived in Shaligrama, not far from Navadvipa, near the present Muragachha station of the Eastern Railway; his shripat is there.[3] He held a high post under the ruler of Gauda, from which he received the title “Sarakhela” — “chief,” “commander” — and great wealth (“Bhakti-ratnakara” 12.3875–3878).[4] Yet it was not this that made him renowned: he and his brothers were pure in character and spotless in people's eyes, and the virtues of Surya Dasa himself, a large-hearted man, were beyond counting. Above all there was his faith in Nityananda. Krishnadasa Kaviraja, listing the branches of Nityananda's tree, names both brothers together:

“Suryadasa Sarakhela and his brother Krishnadasa had unshakable faith in Nityananda. They were full of love for God.” (CC, Adi 11.25)

Around 1409 of the Shaka era (≈ 1487), says one of the biographies, Jahnava appeared in the world to Bhadravati, the wife of Surya Dasa Sarakhela of Ambika-Kalna.[5] The day of her appearance is the ninth day of the bright fortnight of Vaishakha, “Gaura-navami”; on that same day the appearance of Sita Devi, the eternal consort of Ramachandra, is also celebrated. Our calendar marks it in the same way: on the Gaura-navami of the month of Madhusudana it remembers the appearance of Nityananda's shakti Sri Jahnava Devi and of Rama's shakti Sri Sita Devi.[6]

Surya Dasa's Dream

When his daughters came of age, Surya Dasa began to wonder to whom he should give them. At that time a certain Krishnadasa of Borgachhi near Shaligrama, son of Harihara, a kayastha and a devotee of Nityananda, took it upon himself to find a wife for Nityananda. And an old brahmana of Shaligrama, seeing how anxious Surya Dasa was, revealed to him who Nityananda was: the son of Harai Pandita and Padmavati of Ekachakra — in Krishna-lila, Vasudeva and Rohini — Balarama Himself, who had wandered through all the holy places, and the eternal husband of his daughters.

One night, having sat up late with these thoughts, Surya Dasa fell asleep and saw a dream: he was giving both his daughters to Nityananda. Nityananda appeared to him as Balarama Himself, and Vasudha and Jahnava, shining brighter than gold and kunkuma, in jewelled ornaments and many-coloured garments, stood at His left and right in the forms of Revati and Varuni, lighting up all ten directions with their radiance. Surya Dasa forgot himself in rapture ("Bhakti-ratnakara" 12.3901–3911):[7] Nityananda granted him this vision of His majesty to delight His devotee.

In the morning Surya Dasa told his dream to a brahmana friend: "Until He accepts them, I shall have no peace." He sent his friend to Navadvipa, to Srivasa, in whose house Nityananda was then staying. Nityananda sent word that He would fulfil Surya Dasa's wish, and Advaita Acharya, hearing of it, said, "Let it happen soon." The brahmana returned to Shaligrama with the good news.

Krishnadasa, son of Harihara (one of the biographies calls Harihara a king and the village Boroganchhi), took upon himself a splendid wedding in his own house and prevailed on Nityananda to come.[8] Srivasa, Advaita, Chandrashekhara, Murari Gupta and many others gathered with sankirtana; devotees from Shaligrama came too. Surya Dasa ran out to meet Nityananda, fell at His feet and could not utter a word for tears. Nityananda, laughing with joy, embraced him, and Gauridasa, watching his brother, rejoiced as well.

On the eve of the wedding the adhivasa was performed in the house of Krishnadasa Sarakhela in Shaligrama, with the brahmanas of Borgachhi and Shaligrama present.[9] Then Surya Dasa, according to rite and custom, gave both his daughters to Nityananda. "Both by the custom of the world and by scripture Surya Dasa is fortunate," says the "Bhakti-ratnakara": "he gave his two daughters to Nityananda-chandra" (12.3983).

One of the biographies stresses that the wedding was performed "according to human custom." This does not mean that Nityananda entered into a worldly union. Every vishnu-tattva has three energies — Shri, Bhu and Nila (Lila) — and Nityananda, being vishnu-tattva, possesses them too; Vasudha and Jahnava are His eternal shaktis, and the marriage only disclosed to people what exists eternally.

The Newly-Weds

After the wedding Nityananda stayed for some time in Shaligrama and then came with both wives to Navadvipa, to Shachi Devi. Seeing Vasudha and Jahnava, Shachi embraced them again and again, sat them on her lap and pinched their cheeks affectionately; all the mistresses of the Vaishnava households of Navadvipa surrounded the young wives with love as well. At Shachi's request Nityananda stayed on in Navadvipa.

On her advice He took His wives to Shantipura, to Advaita. Sita Thakurani received them with delight and embraced them as tenderly as Shachi had. They stayed with Advaita until Uddharana Datta invited Nityananda to Saptagrama, where a great sankirtana festival went on for several days; from there the way led to Borograma, and Nityananda wandered, leading kirtana. At last He settled for good in Khardaha on the Ganges.[10]

In Khardaha Nityananda had a house where Vasudha and Jahnava lived; Parameshvari Dasa served them. Jahnava had no children. Vasudha bore a son, Virabhadra (Virachandra), and a daughter, Ganga Devi; Virabhadra is revered as an incarnation of Kshirodakashayi Vishnu, and Ganga as an incarnation of the holy river Ganges.

Mother of a New Generation

After Nityananda's departure the work of an acharya fell to Jahnava. Jiva Gosvami and the other Gaudiya acharyas gave her the place of jagad-guru, and so did Srinivasa Acharya, Narottama Thakura, Shyamananda and the other acharyas of the next generation. The sankirtana festivals that Srinivasa, Narottama and their companions carried everywhere took place by her mercy and under her guidance — as also under the guidance of Vishnupriya Devi. When Nityananda, Advaita, Srivasa and many other associates of Mahaprabhu had left the world, Jahnava wished to flood the world with the nectar of sankirtana even more abundantly than before.

Before setting out for Vrindavana, Srinivasa came to Khardaha. Parameshvari Dasa led him to Vasudha, Jahnava and Virachandra; Srinivasa prostrated himself before them in tears, and Jahnava placed her feet on his head, blessing him with the dust of her feet. He stayed there several days, received the mercy of both mothers and the blessing of Virabhadra, and Jahnava, together with other associates of the Lord, seeing his devotion, told him to go to Vrindavana (“Bhakti-ratnakara” 4.86–96); from Khardaha he went on to Khanakula, and on returning to Yajigrama he told his mother of Jahnava's command and received her blessing.

Narottama too visited Khardaha — after his time in Vrindavana. Parameshvari Dasa brought him into the inner apartments of the house, to the feet of Jahnava and Vasudha. Understanding that he had already received the mercy of Lokanatha and Jiva, they bestowed their own generously upon him; here the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (8.213) calls both queens, Vasudha and Jahnava, knowers of all truth. For four days Narottama spoke with them about Krishna, and then went on to Khanakula-Krishnanagara.

Her stepson, Vasudha's son Virabhadra, also became her disciple in diksha. According to the “Prema-vilasa” (24.699–704), he once saw her in a four-armed form — and his heart was changed: he resolved to take initiation from none other than her, his aunt and stepmother.

The Road to Kheturi

Narottama Thakura planned a great festival in Kheturi on Phalguna-purnima, the appearance day of Mahaprabhu. The host was Raja Santosha Datta, the son of Narottama's brother and his disciple; all three acharyas came together — Narottama, Shyamananda and Srinivasa. The “Bhakti-ratnakara” (1.429–434) tells how the associates of Mahaprabhu in Bengal rejoiced in Narottama. Jahnava rejoiced too — the daughter of Surya Pandita, the consort of Nityananda, honoured by the whole world, who generously gives away the jewels of prema: his very name filled her with joy, and his renunciation and extraordinary love for Krishna gladdened her still more. And she graciously set out for Kheturi so that all might see her.

A large company of Nityananda's associates went with her from Khardaha: Parameshvari Dasa, her uncle Krishnadasa Sarakhela, Madhava Acharya — Nityananda's son-in-law, Raghupati Vaidya, Minaketana Ramadasa, Murari Chaitanya Dasa, Jnanadasa, Mahidhara, Sri Shankara, Kamalakara Pippalai, Gauranga Dasa, Nakadi, Krishna Dasa, Damodara, Balarama Dasa, Sri Mukunda and Vrindavana Dasa Thakura, as well as Srivasa's brothers Shripati and Shrinidhi.[11] The “Bhakti-ratnakara” (10.375–382) names separately among her companions Parameshvari Dasa, Kamalakara Pippalai, and Bhagavan Acharya with his son Raghunatha Acharya, and of her companions, Minaketana Ramadasa among them, it says that the mere sight of such Vaishnavas sanctifies the three

worlds. Her disciples Jnanadasa and Manohara Dasa went with her, and, according to the "Prema-vilasa," little Kanu Thakura as well. At Katwa she was joined by Kala Krishnadasa of Akai-hata ("Bhakti-ratnakara" 10.409).

First the travellers came to Ambika-Kalna, to the house of Gauridasa Pandita. His disciple Hridaya Chaitanya welcomed everyone warmly, and Jahnava cooked an offering for the Deities of Gaura and Nityananda with her own hands. After a night of festival they went on to Navadvipa.

In Navadvipa the sorrow of separation awaited her. In Mahaprabhu's house she did not find Shachi Devi — she was no longer in this world — and she grieved for her. Shripati and Shrinidhi took her to their home, but neither Srivasa nor Malini was there, and Jahnava wept. In the morning they went on to Shantipura. Learning that Advaita and Sita Thakurani had already departed, she grieved again; Advaita's sons Achyutananda and Gopala received her and all the Vaishnavas with due honour.

The way then led to Teliya-Budhari: there Govinda Kaviraja, the brother of Ramachandra Kaviraja, met her reverently and worshipped her.[12] After a night's rest all set out for Kheturi. On the far bank of the Padma, Raja Santosha Datta had prepared a huge boat for the crossing and, beyond the river, palanquins, carts, lodgings, prasada and decorations; he himself went far out to meet Jahnava with flowers, garlands and gifts. Srinivasa and Narottama came out to meet her too; each guest was given a separate house and servants.

The Festival at Kheturi

Singing sankirtana, the company led by Jahnava entered Kheturi. Srinivasa, Narottama and Shyamananda prostrated themselves before her in the very dust of the road. Handsome houses had been built in advance for her companions.

On the eve of Mahaprabhu's appearance day the last preparations went forward at her command. In the evening, before the sankirtana began, Narottama offered her sandal paste and garlands and honoured her; Srinivasa too offered her sanctified sandal and garlands. At her word Nrisimha Chaitanya Dasa adorned Srinivasa, Shyamananda and Narottama with garlands and sandal. Jahnava sat on a raised seat at the front of the hall. Raghunandana of Shrikhanda led the kirtana first, and then, at the bidding of Jahnava and Achyutananda, Narottama began to sing; Gauranga Dasa, Gokula Dasa and Vallabha Dasa responded, and Devi Dasa played the mridanga. In the midst of the assembly Jahnava, the shakti of Nityananda, shone with beauty, and the very sight of her and of the devotees, together with the kirtana, purified even the godless and the sinful. They sang until midnight.

Narottama manifested six Deities in Kheturi — Gauranga, Vallabhikanta, Vrajamohana, Krishna, Radhakanta and Radharamana. They were installed at Jahnava's direction: the whole festival took place under her guidance, and at her word Srinivasa performed the abhisheka and archana of the Deities — the Deities themselves Narottama had manifested at the command of his guru Lokanatha. The next day Srinivasa bathed all six Deities, and at the request of Jahnava and the devotees Narottama sang again — and in the kirtana Gauranga Himself appeared with Nityananda and His eternal associates. After the sankirtana Jahnava offered red abir powder to the Deities, and at her word the devotees began to shower one another with it, as at Holi. At dusk Srinivasa performed the abhisheka in honour of Gauranga's appearance and sang and danced with the devotees all night.

Jahnava herself cooked for the Deities. The next morning, after the night of kirtana and the mangala-arati, as the "Bhakti-ratnakara" relates (10.686–688), Jahnava Ishvari in great joy performed her bath and morning rites, with great eagerness prepared wonderful dishes — rice, vegetables and much else beyond description — and with wonderful ceremony herself offered the bhoga to Gauranga, Vallabhikanta and the other Deities. Skilled in the art of cooking, she quickly made sweets, cakes and

drinks as well, and it was she who directed the whole kitchen.[13] Then Jahnava distributed prasada to the mahantas with her own hands, and when they had eaten, she asked Narottama, Srinivasa and Shyamananda to eat — they dared not disobey, and she fed them with care — and took prasada last of all herself. Outside the hall, meanwhile, Raja Santosha was feeding thousands of people.

The great acharyas — Narottama, Srinivasa and others, themselves teachers of the whole world — felt that they had attained the goal of life by hearing talks about Hari from her lips. And the presence of Jahnava and of the eternal associates of the Lord who were there with her — Raghunandana, Achyutananda, Vrindavana Dasa, Shrinidhi and Shripati, Krishna Mishra, Gokula and many others — made happy all who came to the festival.

A controversy is also connected with the Kheturi festival. The “Prema-vilasa” (19th vilasa) claims that Srinivasa worshipped Gauranga there with the mantra of Radha-Krishna, that the Gosvamis prescribed the worship of Gaura with the ten-syllable Gopala mantra, that Jahnava approved of this, and that on Phalguna-purnima, Gaura's appearance day, all took mahaprasada — that is, broke the fast. One of the biographies regards this as an interpolation by a hand hostile to the Gaura-mantra and to the observance of Gaura's appearance day, and adds that the 19th and 20th vilasas are not a genuine part of the “Prema-vilasa” at all: of the four manuscripts collected for its edition, three ended with the 18th vilasa. Nothing of the kind is found in the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (10th wave): there each of the six Deities is honoured separately, and Narottama calls each by name (10.492, 495–496). For the form, name, qualities and pastimes of the Lord are varied, and therefore the worship of each Deity requires its own mantras — so teach scripture and the mahajanas.

When the time came to part, Raja Santosha in tears presented everyone with gold, cloth and vessels, and Jahnava with her company set out for Vrindavana.

In Vraja

Her holy life was described in detail by Narahari Chakravarti in the “Bhakti-ratnakara”; the eleventh wave of that book is devoted to her journey to Vraja. On the way, in a certain wealthy village, she freed the local godless men and evildoers from sin and bestowed on them love for Krishna. Through Prayaga and Kashi she came to Mathura, visited the birthplace of Krishna, bathed at Vishrama-ghata and entered Vrindavana.

Some of the Vaishnavas of Vraja met her already in Mathura, and in Vrindavana the heads of the community came to welcome her. Parameshvari Dasa, as the “Bhakti-ratnakara” relates, names them: Gopala Bhatta, Bhugarbha, Lokanatha, Krishnadasa Brahmachari, Krishna Pandita, Madhu Pandita and Jiva, — and it is he who named each of them to her (11.102–106; according to one of the biographies, Jiva named them). The Gosvamis fell at her feet, and she in turn bowed before them. Seeing the samadhi of her uncle Gauridasa Pandita in Vrindavana, Jahnava wept uncontrollably (“Bhakti-ratnakara” 11.259).

With the Vaishnavas she visited the principal temples — of Madana-mohana, Govinda and Gopinatha — and the holy places of Vrindavana; the Gosvamis saw to it that she was as well provided for as possible. Then she came to Govardhana, Radha-kunda and Shyama-kunda, and in every place of the pastimes the feelings connected with what had happened there awoke in her.

At Radha-kunda she met Raghunatha Dasa Gosvami, wasted by austerity and ceaselessly chanting the holy names, and blessed him. She spent three days at Radha-kunda in bhajana. Once, sitting on the bank, she heard Krishna's flute and saw Him Himself, and waves of divine love overwhelmed her. The ghata where she bathed and where Krishna appeared to her is called Jahnava-ghata to this day.

Together with the Vaishnavas she went round Vraja-mandala and listened to Jiva Gosvami explaining the “Brihad-bhagavatamrita.” Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati, in his “Anubhashya” to the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” (Adi 10.85), also mentions that Jahnava and other devotees came to Vrindavana during Jiva's lifetime; Jiva provided prasada and lodging for all who came from Gauda.

With her in Vrindavana was the boy Kanu, son of Purushottama Thakura — the future Kanu Thakura, also called Shishu Krishnadasa. He had left Bengal with her at the age of five (according to one tradition, Jahnava adopted him). Seeing what deep feelings lived in the child, Jiva and the other Vaishnavas of Vraja named him Kanai Thakura.

Return to Gauda

Jahnava's journey home, like her journey to Vraja, became a pilgrimage to the places of the Lord's associates.[14] First came Kheturi: Narottama and Ramachandra Kaviraja received her there, and she stayed with them three or four days. Then Budhari, the home of Ramachandra Kaviraja in the present district of Murshidabad.

In Budhari lived Shyamadasa Chakravarti, the brother of Vamshidasa. Jahnava proposed that his daughter Hemalata be given in marriage to Baru Gangadasa, and Shyamadasa, obedient to her word, gave his daughter. After the wedding Jahnava entrusted Gangadasa with the service of the Deity Shyamasundara.

In Ekachakra, Nityananda's birthplace, she was told about His parents — her father- and mother-in-law, Harai Pandita and Padmavati — and she wept in separation from them. A local brahmana showed her the places of Nityananda's childhood pastimes, and she spent the night in the deserted house of His parents, chanting the holy names.

At Katwa, in Kanthaka-nagara, she saw the place where the Lord accepted sannyasa, and wept. There too she met Yadunandana Acharya, and with Srinivasa she went on to Yajigrama.[15] In Yajigrama Srinivasa and his devotees received her with great love; Srinivasa brought her into his house and worshipped her. He had just married for the second time — Gauranga-priya, the daughter of Raghava Chakravarti — and brought his young wife home just when Jahnava, come from Vrindavana, was staying with him. Srinivasa took the dust of her feet, seated her in the place of honour and told his wife to bow to her; Jahnava, seeing the bride's gentle nature and beauty, embraced her affectionately. After staying several days she went on.

In Navadvipa Ishana, the servant of Mahaprabhu's household, was by then a very old man. Entering the Lord's house, Jahnava fainted in ecstasy, and all the devotees wept tears of love. She spent the night in the courtyard of Srivasa, where Mahaprabhu had once begun the sankirtana; maha-sankirtana resounded there until morning, and in a dream Gaurasundara and His devotees appeared to her in various pastimes. In the morning, having bowed many times to the dhama of Navadvipa, she went on to Ambika-Kalna.

The people of Ambika rejoiced. Jahnava remembered the departed Gauridasa and wept, and prayed at the feet of the Deities of Gaura and Nityananda — and during the kirtana Gaura and Nityananda Themselves appeared there. At night, as on the previous occasion, she cooked many dishes, offered them to the Deities and distributed the prasada; in a dream Gauridasa appeared to her together with Gaura and Nityananda, and They blessed her.

She also visited the house of Uddharana Datta, who had already departed from this world; there a sankirtana festival went on for another night, and from there she returned home by boat to Khardaha. She was received with sankirtana, and people crowded to see her. Virachandra and Ganga bowed to her, and she embraced them and, as mothers caress their children, tenderly breathed the fragrance of their heads; Jahnava and Vasudha exchanged respectful greetings. To Vasudha, Virabhadra and all who had

gathered, Jahnava told of the holy places of Gauda- and Vraja-mandala, and she kept Parameshvari Dasa with her as her servant. The story of her pilgrimage is well known among Gaudiya Vaishnavas to this day.

Disciples and Family

Of her first disciple, Virabhadra, we have already spoken. Jahnava also took care of his marriage. According to the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (13.249–255), at her wish Yadunandana Acharya gave Virabhadra his two daughters, Shrimati and Narayani. This took place near Rajabol-hata, in Jhamatpur, where Jahnava had come to the temple of one of her disciples. Yadunandana attained great devotion by her mercy, and both daughters-in-law became her disciples and received the mantra from her hands.[16]

Her disciple in diksha was Nityananda Dasa, the author of the “Prema-vilasa.” She also asked for Ramachandra, or Ramai — the grandson of Vamshivadana, son of Chaitanya Dasa: she initiated him, kept him in Khardaha and herself taught him Vaishnava philosophy (the journal “Gaudiya,” 22.30–37). The whole family of Vamshivadana received her mercy, and his descendants, sheltering under her protection, made Baghnapara their shripat. Jnanadasa of Kandra in Birbhum was also her disciple, and with him his friend Manohara Dasa, a compiler of a collection of padas; both went with her to Kheturi. About Madhavacharya of Jirat — Madhava Chattopadhyaya, husband of Ganga, Nityananda's daughter — opinions differ: some regard him as a disciple of Nityananda, others of Jahnava, still others of Purushottama Thakura.

Parameshvari Dasa, her dear servant, by her mercy saw Gopinatha together with Radha in Vrindavana. Returning to Khardaha, he told Jahnava and Vasudha about it, and Jahnava, overwhelmed with love, told him to go without delay to Antpur (Atpur) and install Radha-Gopinatha there. She also had a Deity of Radha made and sent it to Vrindavana, to Sri Govindadeva; the same Parameshvari Dasa accompanied Radha.[17]

The title “kaviraja” — “king of poets” — was given to Ramachandra and his brother Govinda by Jiva Gosvami.[18]

Departure

About when and how Jahnava left this world the biographies say little; two of them are entirely silent. One names the ninth day of the bright fortnight of Vaishakha as the day of her departure — the very day that other sources and our calendar honour as her appearance day.[19] The year has not been preserved.

According to tradition, she went to Vraja for the last time together with Parameshvari Dasa, and he saw how, in the temple of Gopinatha, Jahnava entered the body of Srimati Radhika — returning to her eternal abode, to Her service.[20]

Deities and Places of Remembrance

Gopinatha is the Deity especially close to Jahnava. In Gauda-mandala, Abhirama Thakura manifested the service of Gopinatha in Khanakula-Krishnanagara; in Kshetra-mandala, in Puri, Gadadhara Pandita serves Gopinatha together with Radha and Ananga-manjari, that is, Jahnava; in Vrindavana, Madhu Pandita serves Gopinatha, the Deity of life's highest goal, together with Radha and Jahnava — Ananga-manjari.

In Ekachakra a Deity of Jahnava Mata was later installed to the right of Bankim-raya; the local sevaites explain this by saying that Nityananda entered into Bankim-raya.

She also had her own “gadi” — seat — at Sukhasagar. When the Ganges swallowed the temple of Sukhasagar, the Deities of her gadi, together with the Deities of Purushottama (Nagara), which had

earlier been brought there from Beledanga, were moved to Sahebdanga-Berigram, and when that place too was ruined, to Chandure, in Nadia district (Chakdaha police station), a mile from Simurali station and from Palpara. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati also writes of this in his “Anubhashya” (to CC, Adi 11.39). When one of the biographies was written, the Deities had already been in Chandure for about fifty years.

The temple in Chandure was then a thatched hut with mud walls. There Jagannatha, Balarama and Subhadra are worshipped, two pairs of Nitai-Gaura, Gopinatha, Jahnava Mata, Bala-Gopala, five pairs of Radha-Govinda, Revati and Balarama, and a shalagrama. Some of the Deities were installed by Purushottama; the rest, it is said, came from Jahnava's gadi, which is why the shripat is also called the “pat of Vasu and Jahnava.” Here the service passed from mahanta to mahanta: Gopala Dasa, Ramakrishna, Bihari Dasa, Rama Dasa, another Gopala Dasa and at that time the aged Sitanatha Dasa.

Revati and Ananga-manjari

Who is Jahnava in the eternal pastimes of Krishna? Kavi Karnapura answers in the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika”:

“His two beloveds, Vasudha and Jahnavi — Sri Varuni and Revati, born in the line of Revata — are the daughters of the great-souled Sri Suryadasa, radiant as the sun, who is Kakudmi.” (GGD 65)

Varuni and Revati are the consorts of Balarama; Kakudmi is Revati's father. Read in the order of the names, the verse makes Vasudha Varuni and Jahnava Revati. But the next verse adds something more:

“Some even in the age of Kali declare Sri Vasudha-devi [to be Ananga-manjari], and some say Jahnavi is Ananga-manjari. According to the former rule [of distinct manifestations], the saints hold both to be correct.” (GGD 66)

Ananga-manjari is the younger sister of Srimati Radhika, the daughter of Vrishabhanu. One of the biographies, following this verse, says that in truth both sisters are manifestations of Ananga-manjari. Another remarks that both opinions — Revati and Ananga-manjari — are true, for several eternal personalities may combine in one associate of the Lord.[21] A third calls Jahnava Ananga-manjari without qualification and explains: a shakti is non-different from her possessor, the shaktiman, and so she, the shakti of Nityananda-Balarama, is the younger sister of Radha.

As Ananga-manjari she eternally abides to the right of Tota-Gopinatha in Puri and to the right of Gopinatha in Vrindavana.[22] Radha, Lalita and Vishakha love her boundlessly. Ananga-manjari is happy when she unites Radha with Krishna, and Radha rejoices in just the same way in bringing her younger sister to Krishna.[23] Gopinatha is the lord of the life of both Gadadhara and Jahnava; Bhaktivinoda Thakura calls Nityananda-Gopinatha the treasure of her life.

A Guru in a Woman's Form

One who regards a spiritual master as an ordinary mortal because he has appeared as a woman, a householder, a child, a youth or in a low family will not attain the good. The form in which the guru comes into the world does not diminish his position: Hanuman appeared among monkeys, Prahlada and Bali among asuras, Haridasa among mlecchas, Vasudeva (the future Madhvacharya) as a child, and Goda Devi, Jahnava, Gangamata, Hemalata Thakurani and others as women; and all of them are gurus for the whole world. A guru is one who knows the truth about Krishna. So Mahaprabhu teaches in His conversation with Ramananda Raya:

“If a person has realized the truth about Krishna, he is a true guru, whether he be a brahmana, a sannyasi or a shudra.” (CC, Madhya 8.127)

Shelter at Her Feet

Narottama Dasa Thakura, in one of his songs of prayer, draws a ladder of mercy: without shelter at Jahnava's feet there is no mercy of Nityananda; without Nityananda's mercy the desires for worldly enjoyment do not go; until they go, there is no mercy of Rupa and Raghunatha; and without their mercy there is no attaining love for the youthful Couple of Vraja. The Vaishnavas say the same: without the mercy of Jahnava Devi, the energy of Nityananda, no one crosses the ocean of birth and death or obtains service to Nityananda and loving service to Those whom He worships — Gaura-Hari and Radha-Krishna.

The great Vaishnava poet Krishna Dasa, in the song “jaya radhe, jaya krishna, jaya vrindavana,” having glorified the name of Krishna, His abode and His associates, at the end begs for Jahnava's mercy: remembering her feet, the insignificant Krishna Dasa sings the holy names.

Closer to our own time Bhaktivinoda Thakura prays to her. Already in the opening lines of the “Kalyana-kalpataru” he asks all the Vaishnavas to show mercy and bring him to Jahnava's feet. In the “Dainyamayi Prarthana” — the prayer of humility — he sings of a soul drowning in the ocean of worldly existence who begs for the boat of Jahnava's feet, the shakti of Nityananda, the teacher of devotion to Krishna; and in the “Lalasamayi Prarthana” — the prayer of longing — he yearns to serve Krishna in a perfected spiritual body at the feet of a sakhi and cries out: “Jahnava, be merciful to me now!” In his songs of petition to Gopinatha — “Gopinatha, You are my hope,” “Gopinatha, I am Yours” — there is so much anguish of separation and loving rasa that if even a particle of it sincerely enters the heart, the soul easily crosses the ocean of worldly existence and becomes worthy of eternal service to Gopinatha.

Vrindavana Dasa Thakura, the Vyasa of Chaitanya's pastimes, boldly proclaimed the glory of the Lord of his Lord:

“Sri Gaurasundara is the Lord of my Master. I constantly keep this conviction in my heart.” (CB, Madhya 17.117)

He repeats the same thought elsewhere (CB, Madhya 28.191). And Bhaktivinoda, the Vyasa of our time, prays with humility, placing his hope in Nityananda-Gopinatha — the treasure of Jahnava's life.

Jahnava is glorified also in the “Sri Jahnava-ashtaka” — eight shlokas attributed to Jiva Gosvami; it is listed in the catalogue of the Government Oriental Manuscripts Library in Madras. The ashtaka glorifies the daughter of Surya Dasa Sarakhela, the shakti of Nityananda; the first shloka addresses her as Ananga-manjari, the younger sister of Radhika in Vraja, and the last promises that whoever constantly recites these eight verses will become a bee at the lotus feet of Sri Chaitanya.

1. A shakti and her possessor, the shaktiman, are non-different from each other — and at the same time eternally distinct: the shakti serves the shaktiman (achintya-bhedabheda). Therefore the words “Jahnava is Nityananda Himself” do not erase the distinction between them: Jahnava eternally serves Nityananda and is inseparable from Him.

2. One of the biographies calls Jahnava's uncle who was with her at the Kheturi festival “Krishna Mishra.” Krishna Mishra is the name of Advaita's son, who is named separately among the guests from Shantipura; the names have evidently been confused, and Krishnadasa Sarakhela is meant.

3. One of these biographies says elsewhere that Surya Dasa's house and temple stood in Ambika, a little to the west of Gauridasa's shripat; and the third calls him Surya Dasa “of Ambika-Kalna” (see below).

4. According to another biography, he was the royal treasurer, hence the title; elsewhere the same biography calls him a secretary to the Muslim authorities.

5. From this one may infer that she was also born in Ambika-Kalna, but no biography states her birthplace directly; the other two do not give the year either, and regard Shaligrama as her father's home (see above).

6. One of the biographies gives the eighth day of the bright fortnight of Vaishakha (shukla-ashtami) as her appearance day; another regards the ninth day of the bright fortnight of Vaishakha as the day of her departure (see below, “Departure”).

Here we follow our calendar.

7. One of the biographies places this vision not in the dream but at the wedding: as if Nityananda showed it to Surya Dasa while awake when he offered Him his daughters; but in the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” to which it refers, the vision is part of the dream. The order of the names in the retellings is inconsistent — now “Revati and Varuni,” now “Varuni and Revati” — so they cannot tell us which sister stood on the left and which on the right.

8. One of the biographies confuses this Krishnadasa, son of Harihara, with Krishnadasa Sarakhela, the brides' uncle.

9. According to another biography, all the wedding preparations took place in the house of Krishnadasa in Boroganchhi; and the first one elsewhere mistakenly places the wedding in Shantipura.

10. The sequence of moves after the wedding is given differently: according to one biography — Navadvipa, Saptagrama and Khardaha; according to another — Shaligrama, Navadvipa, Shantipura, Saptagrama and Borogrma.

11. Two lists from different biographies are combined here. Shripati and Shrinidhi appear only in one of them; Krishnadasa Sarakhela, Madhava Acharya, Raghupati Vaidya and others only in the other, while the first names Jahnava's uncle as “Krishna Mishra” (see above).

12. One of the biographies places this meeting “in Kanthaka-nagara,” but Kanthaka-nagara is Katwa, while Govinda Kaviraja lived in Teliya-Budhari.

13. According to the “Bhakti-ratnakara” and all three biographies, she cooked on the morning after the appearance day (one calls this her first offering); but one of them says elsewhere — on the third day of the festival, having bathed at noon “in the Ganges” (though Kheturi stands on the Padma) and cooked rice, vegetables and other dishes of unheard-of taste. The bhoga, according to one of the biographies, was offered to the Deities by Srinivasa; according to the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” by Jahnava herself.

14. The route is given slightly differently: according to one biography — Kheturi, Budhari, Ekachakra, Katwa, Yajigrama, Shrikhanda, Navadvipa, Ambika, Saptagrama and Khardaha; according to another — the same, but without Shrikhanda.

15. The details differ here. According to one account, at Katwa she met Yadunandana Acharya; according to another, she met Srinivasa there and went with him to Yajigrama. Where she went from Yajigrama is also told differently: to Navadvipa or straight to Khardaha.

16. According to another statement of one of the biographies, Narayani was Yadunandana's adopted daughter. Yadunandana himself, according to the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (13.254), became a disciple of Virachandra at the wedding.

17. According to the “Nityananda-vamsha-vistara,” the Deity of Radha was intended for Madana-mohana.

18. So writes one of the biographies, citing the “Anubhashya” to CC, Adi 10.85, and so does another in its chapter on Jiva. But elsewhere this second biography says that Govinda's songs so delighted Jiva Gosvami, Srinivasa Acharya and Jahnava Mata that together they gave him this title.

19. Our calendar marks her appearance on the Gaura-navami of the month of Madhusudana; the day of her departure is not in the calendar.

20. The departure of the Lord's eternal shakti is not death: she never came under the sway of karma and does not leave the world by its law, but only hides her pastimes from our eyes, entering her eternal abode. According to the “Nityananda-vamsha-vistara,” she entered the Deity of Gopinatha, and Gopinatha seated her beside Himself — on His left.

21. One of the biographies retells verse 66 inaccurately — as if the question were whether she is Revati or Ananga-manjari. The verse itself is about something else: which of the two sisters is Ananga-manjari, Vasudha or Jahnavi.

22. According to the “Nityananda-vamsha-vistara,” Gopinatha in Vrindavana seated her on His left (see above, “Departure”).

23. The service of a manjari is the pure love of Vraja, in which there is not a shadow of worldly desire: all her happiness lies in the joy of Radha and Krishna, and Radha Herself rejoices in her service.